Democracy Stress Test: MVP update for Giacomo

For Board 1 (4 Dec 2026) our MVP focuses on one country only: France. The user chooses a scenario first and applies it to France; three scenarios are available (government collapse, financial crisis, integrity scandal).

1. What the MVP looks like

The MVP answers one question: “if this shock hit France, how would trust, turnout and radical voting move?”

Very basic features

1. Choose a scenario first: one of the three shocks, at mild, central or severe strength.
2. Apply it to France: the scenario is kept, so the user can switch strength or compare readings without starting again. The same scenario can later be applied to other countries with one click, once they are added.
3. See the baseline: where France stands today on democratic quality (V-Dem), trust (Eurobarometer, CEVIPOF) and radical vote share (election results via ParlGov/PPEG). “Radical” means parties The PopuList classes as far right or far left; CHES adds their positions.
4. See the stressed reading: the change after the shock as a range drawn from past European episodes, never a single number (method in section 3).
5. See why: the reference episodes, the assumptions and their sources, one click away.
6. Re-run it: one command rebuilds every result from the data files in the project. Most sources download freely; ESS, EVS/WVS and the Manifesto Project need a free registration.

Very basic UI: one page. Step 1, a scenario selector; step 2, the country (France only in the MVP). Then three panels side by side: baseline, stressed reading with its range bar, and “how to read this” (what it can and cannot claim). Uncertainty bands are always visible.

Not in the MVP: the social-interaction simulation, the full European panel, a polished dashboard.

2. First three shocks

We start with the three shocks that have the clearest European precedents and open data before and after them. Each episode is used only for the variables its data can support.

Shock	Reference episodes (used for)	Main variables hit
S1 · Government collapse and institutional deadlock	Belgium 2010–11 (trust, vote; not turnout, as voting is compulsory), Spain 2015–16, France 2024–25	Trust in parliament and government, turnout
S2 · Systemic financial crisis	Euro area 2008–13: Spain, Greece, Portugal, Ireland	Radical vote, political trust, fragmentation
S3 · Integrity scandal at the top	Austria 2019 (Ibiza), Spain 2018 (trust, vote); Italy 1992–94 (vote and party system only, as comparable trust data start in 1997)	Trust in parties and government, party system

Austria 2019 and Spain 2018 also brought down governments; we count them under S3 only, so no episode is used twice. Exact dates are in *episodes.csv*.

We use the most recent release of every source (e.g. Eurobarometer spring 2026, V-Dem v16), plus the European Social Survey for trust in the older episodes. Each result is an interpretation, not a prediction: “if a shock like this hit, past episodes suggest effects within this range”.

3. How the range is computed

- **Effect of one episode:** the change in the variable from the last reading before the shock to the first reading after it, minus the change in the EU average (without the episode countries) over the same dates. This removes Europe-wide trends.
- **Strength:** mild = the smallest episode effect, central = the median, severe = the largest. The range bar runs from smallest to largest. With two to four episodes per shock, we say so on screen.
- **Applied to France:** effects are added in percentage points to France’s baseline and kept within 0–100. When France starts below every reference country (as it does on trust), the reading is flagged: the fall may be overstated.
- **Check:** we build S1 from Belgium and Spain only, apply it to France in spring 2024, and compare with what happened in 2024–25.

4. Area: France only

The MVP covers one country, France, our case study: a pre-election diagnostic before the April 2027 presidential, after recent government instability (2024–25).

Other countries come only after Board 1. Because the scenario is chosen first, adding a country means applying the same scenario to it, not rebuilding anything. Belgium and Spain are the natural next candidates, as they lived the episodes our shocks are built on; the final list depends on our data coverage report.

5. Next steps and points for our next check-in

Before Board 1 (4 Dec): S1 and S2 run end to end on France first, including the S1 check above, then S3, still on France only. We are also contacting research centres (CEVIPOF, CEE at Sciences Po) as project owners and setting up user interviews.

To discuss with you next time:

- Valentin’s comments on the Scope Review and our revised deck (dated KRs, graded risks, updated timeline).
- The optional social-interaction simulation: we propose to park it until after Board 2, as no open data give interaction parameters.
- An energy-price shock (Strait of Hormuz, 2026) as a possible later scenario, with data up to September 2026.